The Watch that Ends the Night: Voices from the Titanic

By Allan Wolf

John Snow – The Undertaker

(Pg 45) "And so we begin."

(Preface) My name is John Snow.

You could say that my living is death.

I am the undertaker.

I have come for the bodies.

(Pg 45) I admit to myself what I knew at the first sight of them:

Those are no seagulls. Those are bodies.

My God. My God. My God.

Bodies scattered for miles, in every direction.

Bodies as far as my indifferent eyes can see.

(Pg 88) Occasional errant corpses float solo here and there:

a lone woman (unchaperoned) lists to her side;

her right ear dips into each wave as if listening

for the water to speak her name. She wears

an intricate silk nightgown – robin's-egg blue --

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that billows at the surface.

The gown makes the sound of flapping winds,

but there are no birds. No angels.

INTRODUCTION

April 14, 1912 -- An eerie night on the North Atlantic. The ocean, which is almost never still, was calm. Thousands of stars curtained the sky -- a backdrop to the human drama taking place. The Titanic was sinking slowly into the freezing sea. Nearly 1,500 people died that night. None of the rest survive today. But after more than a century, the disaster has never faded from the world's imagination. Why? What made this disaster more memorable than all the others?

Other disasters were either too big or too small. They happened too fast, or too slowly. The Titanic sank in two hours and 40 minutes. Its cast of characters represented the human race – every rank and station – and they had time to see what others were doing and to think carefully about what they could do, or should do, morally.

The Titanic is remembered not for the horror of the disaster, but for what it teaches us about real people making the ultimate decisions of their lives: Should I take a seat in a lifeboat or give it to someone else. Should I send my wife and children, or should our family stay together? Should I save myself or try to rescue others?

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Harold Lowe – The Junior Officer

(Pg 15) Be aware that on these big passenger vessels,
the "crew" are mostly window washers,
waiters, bellboys, and stewards . . . Oh,
they're nice enough to have around
if you need to have your pillows fluffed,
but they aren't of much use in a real crisis.
When it came time to report back to Commander Bartlett,
the White Star Line's marine superintendent,
I said,

> "We have tested and inventoried the lifeboats, sir.
> And we find them stocked and ready."

But I was thinking,

> ***God help us if we actually need them,***
> ***since half the crew won't know***
> ***which end of an oar goes in the water.***

E.J. Smith – The Captain

(Pg 16) Do not speak to me of lifeboats.
Titanic has twenty lifeboats all told.
Four boats more than regulations require.
A stable ship like Titanic is life boat enough.

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Of course I am not so foolish as to call her unsinkable.
But I will say this: it would take a fool to sink her.
I may be many things, but I am no fool.

(Pg 96) I will say this with the certainty my thirty years at sea allow
any absolute disaster involving the passengers is inconceivable.
Whatever happens, there will be time enough
before the vessel sinks to save the life of every person on board.

Bruce Ismay – The Businessman

(Pg 17) Lifeboats?
Why clutter a ship's boat deck with lifeboats?
First-class passengers would rather see the sunrise.

The Iceberg

(Pg 7) I am the ice. I see tides ebb and flow.
I've watched civilizations come and go,
give birth, destroy, restore, be gone, begin.
I watched as Abraham and Moses spoke.
I watched as Christ was nailed upon the cross.
I am the ice. I've seen the ebb and flow.

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I carved out massive valleys as I moved.
At last the frozen river mad its way
and calved me with a splash in Baffin Bay.
Since then I've traveled southward many weeks,
for now that my emergence is complete,
there is a certain ship I long to meet -- ***Titanic***
(Pg 121) Titanic leaves the land behind.
The Viking, Spaniard, Frenchman, German, Brit;
the rich, poor, blessed, cursed, brilliant, daft, or dim;
some of them make it, and some of them do not.
Indifferent to all that, the Iceberg floats.
The pinnacle of these humans' ingenuity
means nothing to the Iceberg's cold enormity;
the largest moving thing man can devise
is but a trifling dust caught in my eyes.
As if she were no larger than a pea,
she shrinks into the vastness of the sea.

Fredrick Fleet – The Lookout

(Pg 202) Me job as lookout allowed me to watch
all kinds of people: poor, well off, and bloody rich.
Titanic's crew ain't so different from the passengers.
The first-class passengers ain't so different

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from the second-class or the third. They all use the loo.
They all go in to dinner. They all laugh and cry.
They all have a future. They all have a plan.
They all hold hands with their little ones.
And from where I sits in the crow's next,
a rich man and a poor man looks equally small.

The Iceberg

(Pg 283)I am the ice. My next maneuver barely makes a sound.
As you rush through darkness to my side,
the ice has flipped, exposing only black.
Black ice; clam seas; no wind; a moonless sky.
Could Fate provide a better place to hide?
I see her, but she does not see me.
The lookouts on her mast can't make me out.
Make haste, now. Hurry. Bring heir hearts to me.
And do let's get acquainted as you wish.
I hear the clock hands tick.
Shhh. Tick. Tick. Tick. Tick. Tick . . .

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Fredrick Fleet – The Lookout

(Pg 290) CLANG! CLANG! CLANG!

I keep my eyes fixed

on the monster emerging from the night.

"Iceberg! Iceberg, straight ahead!"

E.J. Smith – The Captain

(Pg 302) "UNCOVER THE BOATS!"

I was giving out order left and right. But I really had no plan.

Two thousand two hundred and eight souls.

Twenty boats.

The mathematical disparity stung my brain.

(Pg 325) "Women and children, please! Women and children!"

Harold Lowe – The Junior Officer

(Pg 310) Finding passengers willing to get into the boat

proved difficult. Not that I can blame them.

Descending in a boat is a dangerous thin,

And the likelihood of Titanic actually sinking --

well, the very idea was ridiculous at the time.

I admit that the first lifeboat was only half full,

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but what was I to do, pull out my pistol and force people?

"Lower away! Lower away! Lower away!"

Bruce Ismay – The Businessman

(Pg 348) I was in the right place at the right time.

You'd make me your scapegoat

because I took a descending boat.

Was I to let it pass me by?

There was a space. An empty seat.

What would it serve, then not to fill it?

Is it my moral duty to stay with the ship?

Yes, other had been turned away.

Yes, other men had been denied.

I took no part in that.

In fact, I helped the women in

and then stepped back while the ladies sat.

Decorum dictates you must die;

common sense requires you live.

I'll choose the time and place I face

my moral responsibility.

I was in the right place at the right time.

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The Iceberg

(Pg 367) The hull cannot withstand the water's weight.

And at long last, she slips into the deep.

And where the great Titanic used to be,

behold the souls left floating on the sea.

(Pg 368-369)

god help us so cold
our father who art in heaven over her children
please hey you in the boats
Love you my darling hold my hand
bring back the boats We'll stay together
we're over here my god Follow my voice
can't stop shaking Come back daddy will protect you
so cold Come back hurts to breathe
cannot swim We're over here my god
help us Are they coming back so cold
someone please

Harold Lowe – The Junior Officer

(Pg 377-378) The mighty Titanic was gone.

I could hear (as well as anyone)

the terrible cries of those dying in the water;

I wanted to be sure that none of these lifeboats attempted

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an ill-considered rescue that would result in more deaths.

Some women demanded we go back.

"I would rather die than do nothing."

"I think it is our moral duty."

I wanted to be clear that we were NOT rushing in to the rescue.

My boat was already dangerously overcrowded

and it would take just one swimmer,

Swinging a leg up onto the side, to capsize us all.

Yes, many of our boats had empty spaces,

but what good are fifty seats when there are

fifteen hundred fighting each other to fill them?

Let me be quite firm when I say this:

Had any of us rowed a boat into that swarming mass,

Which was alive with thrashing limbs and clawing hands,

we all of us would have wound up dead.

To do so would have been suicide.

And even if it were remotely possible to do so,

who would you choose to come aboard and live?

Who would you choose to stay behind and die?

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